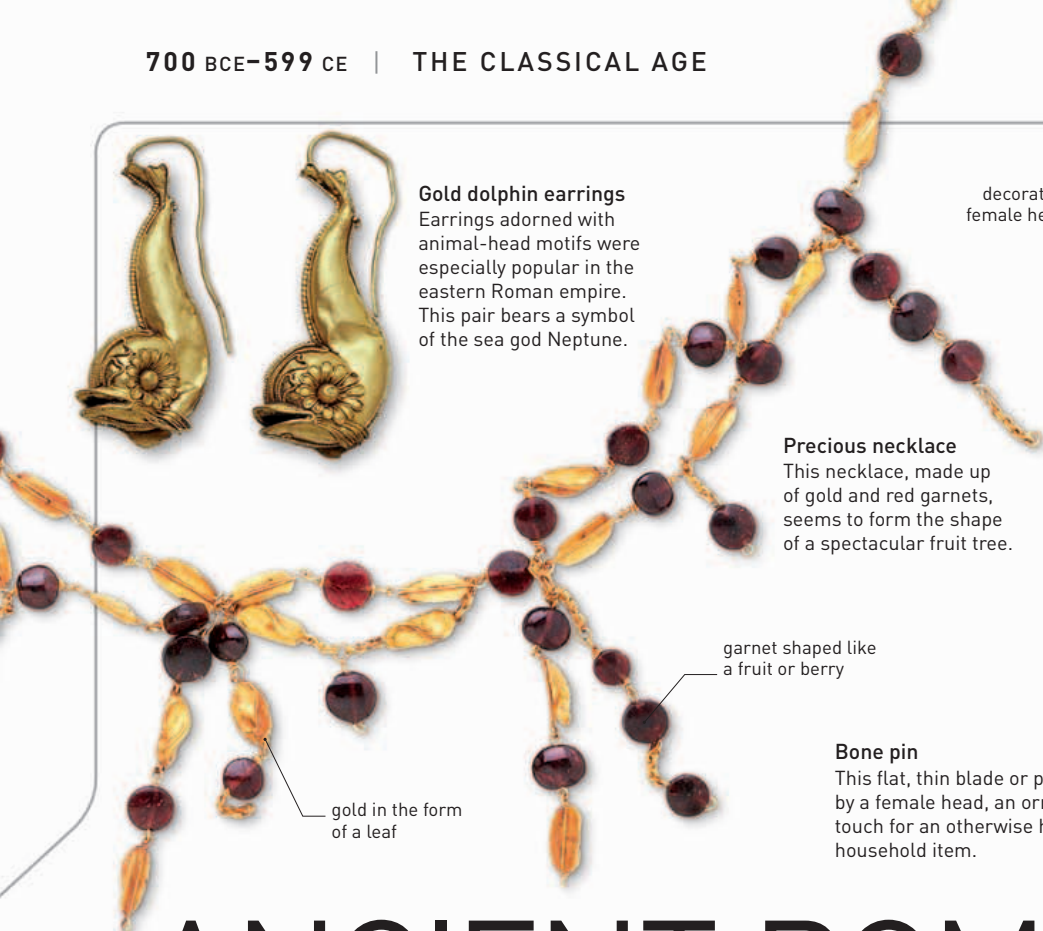




Gold dolphin earrings
Earrings adorned with animal-head motifs were especially popular in the eastern Roman empire. This pair bears a symbol of the sea god Neptune.



Precious necklace
This necklace, made up of gold and red garnets, seems to form the shape of a spectacular fruit tree.

garnet shaped like a fruit or berry

gold in the form of a leaf

decorative female head

Bone pin
This flat, thin blade or pin is topped by a female head, an ornamental touch for an otherwise humdrum household item.

Plumb line
This bronze weighted plumb line was attached to a groma, an instrument used by the Romans to survey straight lines.



bronze weight



ANCIENT ROME

THE ROMANS SPREAD A RICH MATERIAL CULTURE THROUGHOUT THEIR VAST EMPIRE

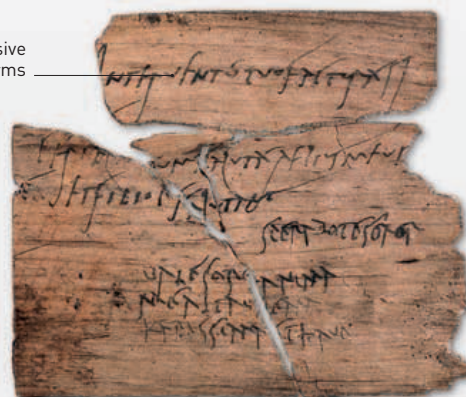
As Roman political control steadily expanded outside Italy, in its wake came the Roman way of life. Roman surveyors laid out new cities, local elites took up Roman practices, and the masses attended gladiatorial spectacles. On a domestic level, Roman fashions in clothing and accessories also spread.

Although many of the territories that the Romans conquered initially resisted, the populations of these provinces, particularly the former ruling classes, gradually adopted many Roman customs. Influential men became Roman citizens, towns were given new public buildings such as baths and courthouses, Roman legionary garrisons were established in strategic places, and new trade routes brought luxury goods from Rome. As a result, similar Roman artifacts have been found across Europe, the Middle East, and North Africa, dating from around the 1st century BCE to the 5th century CE.



head of Oceanus

cursive letter forms



Ocean baths
The most important Roman baths were adorned with lavish mosaics, such as this one of Oceanus, the ocean god, from Sabratha in Libya.

Wooden tablet
This type of tablet, made from very thin wood, was used by the Roman military for everyday letters and record-keeping. This one was found at Vindolanda in England.



central pivot

Bronze dividers and foot rule
Dividers allowed engineers to copy scale plans or models at twice or half their size—the gap between the lower points is always twice that between the upper points. The rule, which was one Roman foot long (11 1/4 in/29.6 cm), folded for easy carrying.

metal crest to deflect blows

lower point

foot rule